

WRITING SAMPLE

5 Common Mistakes Small Business Owners Make When Taking Their Business Online

SEO Blog Article | Speculative Writing Sample

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Objective

To educate beginner entrepreneurs and small business owners about common mistakes that can prevent them from building a successful online business.

Target Audience

Beginner entrepreneurs and small business owners.

Primary Keyword

Starting an online business

Related Keywords

Online business, small business owners, starting a business online, online business mistakes, target audience, online presence, beginner entrepreneur.

Search Intent

Informational

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Introduction

You were probably on cloud nine when you first thought about starting a business. I'm guessing it started with a need for money, and after so much thinking, you realized you could sell something. You probably even calculated that in three months, you'd have made \$10,000.

But this is day 100 of posting, and TikTok isn't even letting you get past 100 views, let alone make any sales.

If you feel that way, congratulations. You're welcome to the reality of being a beginner entrepreneur.

Starting an online business can be exciting, but putting your products or services online is only the beginning. There are several mistakes that can make it harder for people to find you, trust you and eventually buy from you.

In this article, we'll look at five common mistakes small business owners make when taking their businesses online, and what you can do differently.

1. Not Identifying Your Niche

The word "niche" is probably getting on your nerves by now because people won't stop talking about it. But there's a reason everyone keeps talking about it: it matters.

Every small business owner needs to identify a specific area they want to focus on. Think of it like the genres in books. Some people love horror, while others prefer romance. You wouldn't try to sell a romance novel to someone who only reads horror and expect them to immediately become interested.

A niche helps people understand what your business is known for.

Imagine you make a post about electronics today and someone who purchased an electronic from you refers a friend. That friend visits your page expecting to find more electronics, only to discover that your most recent posts are about handbags, perfumes and shoes. They may start wondering, "So what exactly does this business sell?"

This doesn't mean you can never expand your products or services. It simply means you need a clear identity first.

Having a niche also makes it easier to identify your target audience, which brings us to the second mistake.

2. Not Identifying Your Target Audience

Knowing your niche tells people what you do. Knowing your target audience tells you **who you're doing it for**.

I'll use my couture brand as an example. When I started, I was sewing randomly. I made clothes for men, older people and women. I even made bags and other items. As a result, people identified me as a typical tailor, but I knew that wasn't what I wanted to be known for.

Eventually, I picked a niche.

I realized that I love women and the confidence and beauty that clothes can give a woman. I built my niche around that, and naturally, my target audience became women.

But not just any woman.

I began thinking about women who specifically needed what my brand offered: teenage girls, newlyweds, divorcees, widows, single and independent women, new mothers and nursing mothers, among others.

This is the kind of thinking you need to do when starting an online business. Don't just ask, "Who can buy my product?" Ask, "**Who needs this the most?**"

Properly researching your target audience helps you understand their needs, preferences, problems and buying habits. It also helps you create content and advertisements that speak directly to them.

When you understand your audience, you're not simply posting and hoping the algorithm finds somebody. You're giving social media platforms clearer signals about the kind of people your content or ads are intended for.

3. Not Stating a Clear Price

If you're too scared to put your price on display, trust me, your customers feel even worse about asking you for it.

When a potential customer checks out your website or social media profile, they should be able to get enough information about your products or services to decide whether you're within their budget. This includes pricing.

It saves them the embarrassment of enquiring about something only to discover that it's far beyond what they can afford. It also saves you the time of responding to enquiries that were never likely to become sales.

This doesn't mean you must have a fixed price for everything.

If you offer a service where the price depends on the client's requirements, you can provide an estimated price range. For example, instead of simply writing "Contact us for pricing," you could say, "Our custom packages start from ₦50,000."

That's enough to give a potential customer an idea of what they're getting into.

So, head over to your WhatsApp catalogue, website or social media page and update those prices. Make it easier for people to decide whether your product or service is right for them.

4. Having a Poor Attitude Towards Enquiries

Many beginner entrepreneurs don't understand how important their response to a potential customer can be.

When someone sends an enquiry, they are already showing interest in your business. They may not be ready to buy immediately, but they've taken the first step towards becoming a customer.

Taking an extremely long time to respond can communicate laziness or incompetence. Being rude can be even worse.

I once asked a jewellery vendor how much a bracelet cost. Instead of simply telling me the price, she asked if I was ready to buy it immediately.

I told her I wasn't sure I wanted to buy it at that moment; I simply wanted to know how much I should budget for when I was ready.

Guess what her response was?

She told me to come back when I was ready.

Well, I won't ever be ready, because I have no idea what I should get ready for.

That's the problem.

An enquiry isn't an inconvenience. It's an opportunity to build a relationship with a potential customer.

Be polite. Respond as quickly as reasonably possible. Answer the question directly and provide any additional information the customer needs. If they need to take another step before placing an order, make that process clear.

The journey from lead to customer shouldn't feel like hard work.

5. Not Having a Strong Online Presence

Last on the list is a common mistake among small business owners: failing to present themselves properly online.

And no, this has nothing to do with how many followers you have.

You don't need 50,000 followers to have a strong online presence. You need to make it easy for someone who discovers your business to understand what you do and trust you enough to consider buying from you.

Start by being visible. Create your social media pages and keep them active. Post consistently and promote your content instead of waiting for people to magically discover your business.

Pay attention to the quality of the pictures and videos you use. Your online presence is often the first impression a potential customer has of your business, so blurry pictures, incomplete information and an inactive page can work against you.

Your profile should also answer basic questions a potential customer may have:

What do you sell?

Who is it for?

How much does it cost?

How can I place an order?

How can I contact you?

Can I trust this business?

Your online presence should make the answers obvious.

You can also use your platforms to show your work, educate your audience, share customer experiences and consistently remind people that your business exists. You don't have to become an influencer. You simply need to be findable, credible and clear.

Conclusion

Starting an online business doesn't mean creating a social media account today and expecting sales tomorrow. Building a business takes time, but some of the struggles beginners face can be reduced by getting the basics right from the beginning.

Know what you want to be known for. Know who you're selling to. Be transparent about your prices. Treat enquiries like opportunities rather than interruptions. And make sure your business has a strong, professional presence online.

You don't need to have everything figured out before you start. But you should be willing to learn, pay attention to what isn't working and make adjustments as you grow.

After all, being a beginner entrepreneur doesn't mean you have to remain a beginner forever.